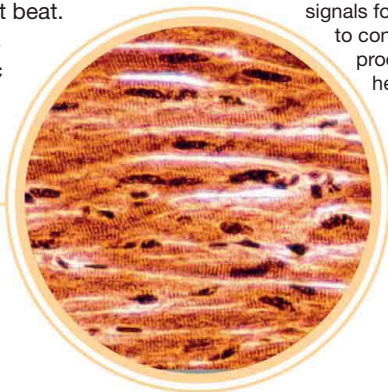


Heart beater

Cardiac muscle is found in the wall of the heart. It contracts automatically thousands of times a day to make the heart beat.

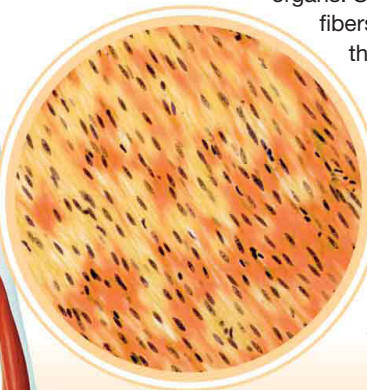
Without us being aware, signals from the brain speed up cardiac muscle contraction when we exercise and slow it down when we rest.

Cardiac muscle is made up of a branching network of interlocking fibers. This passes on the signals for the fibers to contract and produce a heartbeat.



Organ squeezers

Smooth muscle works automatically in the walls of hollow organs, such as the stomach and bladder. When it contracts, it squeezes those organs. Smooth muscle fibers in the irises of the eyes control the size of the pupils.



Smooth muscle has sheets of short fibers that wrap around hollow organs. Under a microscope, the fibers' nuclei appear as dark specks.